

Class Taste

Chains clinked as the black wolf edged his way across the living room, a towering pile of pizza boxes cradled between two large paws tipped with claws. Forced to take small, mincing steps as silver toned manacles encased his ankles, spanned by a short stretch of chain, Don shuffled closer to the corner sofa, large enough to seat seven or eight people, at a bit of a squeeze. A plush purple, the sofa was clearly the choice of a female fur with fine taste, though he had never been invited to sit upon the thick cushions and take the weight off his paws. Whereas the sofa spared no expense, Don's bondage was not really silver, no matter how it falsified its clean. The wolf's ears drooped, blue eyes hazy. His mistress would never waste such an expense on him.

Squatting awkwardly to lower the pizza boxes, branded with a widespread and well known chain, on to the coffee table in front of the sofa and, more importantly, his mistress, he whimpered, a box sliding askew. Panic fluttered in his chest but the Thompson's gazelle, lying with her cloven hooves up in the lap of a male giraffe that he'd never seen before, paid him no mind.

Crowded on the sofa with five friends, all prey mammals, she appeared to be perfectly in her element, brown eyes warm as the soft, living room light complimented her orange coat. Black triangles angled down her muzzle from eyes to nose with a white underside to her jaw and neck while the fur on the upper side of her muzzle shone a deeper russet brown. To complete her natural look, two striped horns rose from her skull. Don grimaced, remembering the number of times she'd caught them on the curtains, peeking out as a younger gazelle. He'd had to take the blame for her and been given a beating for his troubles.

The group laughed and chatted amongst one another as if he was not even in the room as he remained in his squat, awaiting further instruction. His thighs burned but he did not dare rise. His mistress' partner on the sofa was the first to reach for the treat with hoofed fingertips, the giraffe's greedy eyes fixed on the uppermost box. Don's stomach growled loudly, pizza boxes flipping open and releasing their aroma into the air. He'd never had pizza before.

His mistress snapped her fingers.

"Stop eyeing it, slave," the gazelle on the sofa said in a bored tone, ear flicking in his direction. "That food isn't yours and you know that well enough."

The wolf swallowed and cast his eyes down. All he wanted was a slice, just to see how it tasted. It had to be better than plain vegetables. Old vegetables, more often than not.

"Is your slave too much for you to handle, dear Persephone?"

A grey squirrel giggled and cover her mouth politely with her paw as she chewed, holding the slice of pizza away from her body. The morsel dripped with cheese and Don leaned forward, mouth watering.

Would one taste hurt?

"Of course not!" The gazelle shot back.

Don gulped and stayed as still as possible, muscles trembling from holding the pose for so long. He could not risk moving, not with his mistress engaged in conversation involving him right above his head. Though he could have not existed for all their conversation required him to speak.

The gazelle shook her head and slouched back on the sofa, shoulders hunched. Don supposed she was in her early twenties, though he could not remember how old she had been on her last birthday, only that he had been required, as always, to wait on her at her party. It had been an extravagant affair. He hadn't had anything to eat then either. Her parents, his master and mistress, could not have been around if she allowed her posture to slip so terribly. The giraffe, long neck giving him greater sway, arched over to nuzzle her cheek, licking her neck with soft, grey lips.

"Isn't he really your parents' slave?" The squirrel pressed, licking grease off her fingers with relish. "That means he doesn't listen to you. At least mine are mine and they do as they're told." She pointed at Don, who froze. "He's an untrained brute. Why isn't he muzzled? All of *mine* are muzzled. As they well should be."

The gazelle sat up straight, swinging her hooves down to the floor. Reaching for her, the giraffe snorted as he was brushed aside. He hefted his arm over the back of the sofa instead and rolled his eyes, fingers tapping a tune that only he could hear.

"He listens to *me*," she snapped, back rigid. "Do you need me to show you just how obedient this brat of a wolf is?" Persephone jerked her horns towards the slave, who tried to sink into the floor, focusing on a point on the floor between his spread knees. "He'll do whatever I say and be thankful for it too."

The squirrel eyed her, tugging up the strap of her royal blue top from where it slipped down over her shoulder.

"Prove it."

Don took a deep breath, scents thrumming potent on the air. Determination clouded the natural scents, ringing through the clamour of multiple mammals seated around the room. He didn't have to sift through the scents to pick out Persephone's tone. A steely edge rang through like the clang of a knife on a metal saucepan – he'd heard that sound many a time from the resident lion chef in a bad temper, feeling it fitting now – and he quailed into the ground. Pressing his muzzle into the carpet, in inhaled in short, sharp breaths, striving to calm himself.

But it was not good. His heart pounded, sweat matting the fur under his arms with sickly dread. Whatever he wanted did not matter, only what Persephone had in store for him. And that would come whether he agreed to it or not. Such was the life of a slave.

Standing over the prostate wolf, the gazelle tapped one cloven hoof.

"Slave."

Don pricked his ears unwillingly.

“Lie down on the floor.”

The wolf’s ears slipped back to his skull and he obediently stretched out on his front, slipping from his knees until his thighs pressed flat. That was easy. Perhaps it would be as simple as an obedience test, playing him like a trained dog. He could deal with that.

“And up.”

He shuffled back, pushing up with his paws, but was shoved down with a hoof between his shoulder blades. Holding his breath, Don wagged his tail, keeping it low and submissive. Though a prey animal would not recognise a lupine display of submission, he hoped it would get his meaning across.

“Backside up,” she clarified, a wet snort erupting from flared nostrils. “Do not play dumb with me, slave. You know far better than that.”

Her fear was palpable on the air, garbed with a lick of doubt. Don whimpered and pushed his hips back until his forearms were flat on the ground, fingers spread, and his bare rear was as high as he hoped she wanted it. He licked his lips, mouth dry. It seemed silly to have wanted the pizza after all that. But what did she want with him? The only time he had been put on such display was when... Don’s eyes widened and he gulped.

He’d done nothing wrong!

Sliding the belt from her waist – a fashion statement that cinched in her already small waist – Persephone ran it between her fingers and doubled it back on itself. The woven fabric would be worthless for a true beating, a punishment to leave an impression, yet its implications made her friends balk, eyes bulging out of their skulls.

The squirrel shook her head and reached out as if to stop her friend, jaw slack in a fashion that Don may have found amusing if not for his predicament. A soft mewl escaped her lips like a breath of wind, too frail to make a difference. She was not the brightest of Persephone’s friends. She wouldn’t have had any idea of the trouble she was causing, what drama she stirred up through foolish words.

“Persephone...”

The gazelle silenced her with a look that could have stayed an executioner’s paw.

“Stay still, slave.”

Persephone stood over him, towering. For a gazelle, that should have been impossible but Don quailed into the ground as her arm swung back, a shadow dropping over his rump as her weapon of choice cut across the soft overhead light, sensually illuminating the scene as if from a theatrical performance. Prey always had needed tools to subdue predators, which only highlighted the difference between them. They held no natural weapons to compare, faced one on one. The line of the wolf’s jaw hardened. His tail he tucked down for some protection. He had not been ordered to raise it for the beating.

When the whistling blow came, it was lighter than he expected, yet only half a second later the lithe gazelle drew her arm back for the second and the third and the fourth. A flurry of strikes rained down on his exposed rump as if he was a petulant pup being punished, a stinging burn rising. The woven belt had been deceptive – it *stung* something fierce! Don closed his eyes, blocking out the glare of the world, and counted as high as he could remember, distracting himself from the tedious curve of pain.

The squirrel giggled. He knew it was her. Only she had such a high pitched voice. The wolf howled into the carpet and pressed his paws together tightly, trembling. Sweat soaked his fur and the acrid stench made his nose wrinkle, a brief distraction from the shame. The squirrel cooed, murmuring something that he could not catch yet did not need to in order to understand. She took pleasure in his subjugation – it had been her motivation all along, such a ruse. She had never cared for his wellbeing, that Persephone would not beat him. Just like the rest of them. They were all the same, no one different to the rest in the herd.

Whereas the pain came to an end after a couple of minutes, maybe even three, the humiliation scarred Don's soul. The wolf snuffled into the carpet, nose streaming and eyes watering, though he turned his muzzle away. Putting her belt aside on the table, Persephone yanked him up by the leather collar and he yelped, counting his blessings in the next instant that he no longer had to wear the muzzle, caging in his fangs. That hurt like the blazes when the collar was pulled, cutting into his lips until they bled.

She struck him flat across the muzzle with the palm of her paw and he couldn't stop himself. Instinct took over and a snarl ripped itself from his throat, lips lifting up from teeth. It was weak, however, a dream of a memory from the time when his kind *had* voice, back when they had a snarl.

Oh, how times changed. Persephone smirked and petted him between the ears like she would do a pet, harder than necessary.

"Look at that muzzle, so fine."

The gazelle crooned as she tilted the wolf's head from the left to the right, admiring him from all angles as his amber eyes remained stoic and impassive. He willed his hackles to lie flat. If he fought back, he'd be locked up again but he could smooth that blasted snarl from his muzzle! Don broke and whined plaintively, fear still rumbling about his muzzle, eyes rimmed with an edge of white.

"This is why we chain you, sweet pea." She traced a finger over the muzzle as the wolf's snarl deepened, heart hammering and blood roaring in his ears. "So you *cannot* submit to baser instinct like your kind did long ago. You *cannot* have everything you want with no repercussions. Life is not like that anymore and it never will be again. This is a better time with prey binding you to submission. Wolves like pack behaviour, don't they?"

She giggled, eyes brighter.

"And you know where your position is in this pack. Right at the very bottom rung. Below it, even."

She pushed him to the floor, disinterested with him now that she had made her point as clearly as only she could. Pressing his muzzle into the carpet, the pain dropped from Don's muzzle and he stared forlornly at the legs of the coffee table as Persephone's friends devoured the pizza, the gazelle in her rightful place perfectly in their midst. The curl to his lips slipped away, lips once again covering his teeth as if to act as a gag, and the wolf curled into a ball, hugging his knees to his chest. He did not pretend that tears rolled down his muzzle, dripping off the end of his nose. No one would notice anyway.

The wolf flinched from their laughter and happy voices, sharing food as if it was the most normal thing in the world – well, perhaps for them. All he'd wanted was one, bite, just one, single bite. Had that been too much to ask? And he could have snapped and he could have snarled again, taking what he thought he deserved in the heat of the moment. Yet the rocking, whimpering wolf beside the table made no such move, though the heat of anger seared painfully through the cavity of his chest. He was not sure there was anything left there anymore. And he did not snarl, no he would not snarl.

He did not snarl because he was a predator.

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“What's got your tail so stiff?”

A wild dog, African, lay flat on a narrow bed with a thin mattress, jiggling a hind paw over the edge. His coat splashed through with orange, brown and white in no discernible pattern, shades blending seamlessly into one another as if he had been groomed with an artist's brush, though his dark eyes followed Don's restless pacing with hardened focus.

The wolf strode the length of the dormitory bedroom, situated in the pit of the basement, and threw a mental punch at the patch of damp streaking the corner of the ceiling where it met the wall. The master and mistress would never fix that, not unless it pleased them to do so. And the slaves were the only ones ever to be found in the dorm, so why would they ever concern themselves with such a trivial need? No! They had parties and college and high flying jobs and *lives* to be getting on with. No need to worry about the needs of those they owned, who lived by their grace and generosity.

The canine snapped his fingers.

“Don!”

The wolf shook himself, amber eyes hazy.

“Sorry... Sorry, Rafa,” Don said, tongue thick in his mouth. “Didn't mean to ignore.”

Studying him, Rafa said nothing, the white tip of his tail flicking hypnotically, hanging over the edge of the bed. Like the wolf, the canine wore nothing but his fur, which, for him, could have been pattern and cover enough. Sometimes Don was jealous of the colours in his fur and wished he could be garbed as such in finery.

The wolf paced the length of the room, turned on his heel and strode back again, stirring up dust in his passing. No one else had returned to the dorm, presumably occupied with other

tasks within the household, and Don had nothing to occupy his mind beside endless walking within a room he could not escape until the morn. Even relieving himself was strictly controlled and, well, once a slave had entered their evening abode they were not expected to be seen in the public areas of the household. There was no way to reach their bathroom without disturbing the master and mistress.

And Persephone.

Don growled and paced some more, hind paws sore from being on them all day. He should have been resting yet his mind raced from one thought to the next, discarding each in turn as nothing of great interest, unable to settle.

“So what has got you acting like this?” Rafa probed. “Haven’t you got your book to read?”

Don shook his head.

“I lost it.”

Rafa widened his eyes, tail stilling as he half sat up on the bed, elbows bent as he propped up his torso.

“You lost it? But you read that book every night.”

“I know.” Don turned his shoulder to the dog. “But I lost it.”

Rafa shrugged sympathetically. It was hard to lose a possession even if it did not truly belong to them.

“I can’t stick this anymore,” Don snapped, slamming his palm into the wall; a pawful of dust trickled from the ceiling. “All this...constant doing! Don’t we ever get to just forget all of this?”

The wild dog rolled his eyes.

“We’re slaves, Don, there isn’t any forgetting involved. How do we forget what our lives are every single day until we die?”

“I don’t know...” He interlocked his fingers behind his head and paused, leaning forward to press his forehead to the cool, grey wall, a sickly neutral shade. “I only know that this life is killing me. It’s crazy. Stupid. Wrong. Obscene.”

“That’s a big word for you.”

“Oh, shut up.”

Don stood perfectly still as the wall warmed to his skin and fur, coolness all too swiftly evaporating. Other predators, his fellows, milled into the dorm in ones and twos until he assumed every bed had its partner within spitting distance, greeting one another with their usual chorus of barks and mewls, depending on species. He ignored them all, thrusting down

the urge to turn and nuzzle his burning backside up to the wall for a scrap of relieving cool. It would be too short lived to make any real difference, just like anything else.

That had to change. The wolf narrowed his eyes, vision enveloped by grey, grey, boring grey wall. And perhaps sooner rather than later, if he had anything to do with it. He would have everything to do with it.

Someone stood at his back, tapping a paw on the floor.

“What’s wrong with you?”

Don shrugged and pushed himself up from the wall, half-turning to glance over the curious younger wolf, a grey male that boasted startlingly blue eyes. It had been his eyes that had secured his place in the household – rare in the slave string of wolves Don had had the luck to know and work alongside.

“I’m getting asking that a lot today.”

“Then why don’t you answer the question?”

The youngster challenged him, back ramrod straight down to his rigid tail. At any other time, Don would have risen to the challenge, the open threat, in the only way he knew how, but found the youngster beneath him this night. Snorting, he flipped his paw dismissively – unknowingly mimicking how the prey treated predators in their paw gestures – and padded over to join Rafa on his bed. The poor excuse for a place to rest his head was barely big enough to fit both of them. Rafa’s paws hung off the end when he lay flat on his back, legs straight.

“Don got his arse whipped.”

“Really?” The grey wolf’s lips fell into a slack-jawed ‘O’. “What did you do? Did you drop a plate? Scuff up the floor? It has to be something bad, you haven’t have a beating in...in...years!”

“Knock it off,” Don growled. “Who cares what happened? It’s no less than the rest of you lot would’ve gotten if you’d been in my place. They were trying to make a point and, well, I happened to be there. Sucks to be me.”

“Sucks to be all of us,” Rafa chipped in, voice low enough that only Don’s sharp hearing caught his words.

“Yes...” The wolf said slowly, loudly. “It sucks to be all of us.”

Leaping up from the bed, though he had had little time in which to rest, the wolf took centre stage, encircled by bright-eyed predators. He spread his arms wide, encouraging them in closer and closer, close enough to hear him clearly, even though the wolf had never learned to throw his voice. He barked, tail set in challenge. Even Rafa lifted his head from the bed, acknowledging the call, and, albeit slowly, rose to his paws, tail wagging.

Pack mentality.

Turning in a tight circle, Don drew strength from the predators gathered around him, standing shoulder to shoulder with yearning, bright eyes. They hadn't given up yet, even with their collars and chains, differing between bodies depending on their behaviour and the whims of the master and mistress. They were all there! There for him! His fellow predators would always have his back, not like any master or mistress he had ever had the misfortune to serve.

Not like Persephone. Not like *them*.

"This has to stop and it stops now," Don said, voice wavering at the start and steadying as he spoke. "Why should we do what they want every day, day in and day out? Where's the sense in it? What's the point?"

A leopard snickered, tail curling sinuously back and forth, ever the picture of a restless feline. His spots caught the eye.

"Because we're predators," he said so simply that Don almost felt dumb for posing the question in the first place. "What else are we meant to do? This," he tugged his own collar, "tells us where we belong in the world. It's our place. That is theirs."

He jerked his head towards the door leading to the majority of the house to imply the prey overlords, raising one should in a shrug that he could not be bothered to complete. Don held up his paws, palms facing out, staving off the chorus of rising murmurs. Of course they would see it that way – they had never known anything different, had never challenged the norm. Neither had he, for that matter. But something deep inside, something primal, told the wolf that there was something better out there for them. For him. There was better than what they had.

The wolf shuffled his hind paws, grit and tiny stones digging into the sensitive pads.

"Why?" He asked. "Why are we like this? Because we were subdued once? Why should we have to do what we don't want to do every day? We don't want to do chores and run errands. Prey are more than capable of doing that themselves, there's no great difficulty in the menial. And they don't tell us to do anything of great worth either. So why can't they do it? Why does it fall to us? We were only overthrown *once*."

Don stamped and growled until they fell silent, cowed by the alpha of their little group. The cats hadn't taken well to his quiet leadership in the early days of the household but that had quickly changed. One would conform if they were only encouraged enough and it was only in the best interests of the leopard and serval to follow his guidance. The canines and lupines were easier, more like him than the rest. Though they did not think, they would never think.

He twisted his fingers into the thick fur of his neck and yanked out hair with a half-stifled yelp, swallowing the turmoil. He didn't have to educate them but he had to show them a better way, he had to help them and help himself. Don panted with his lips parted, pink tongue lolling from his muzzle. He would *make* them think if they did not want to take the step themselves.

"We *can* take back what's ours," he insisted, stepping forward so they were forced to break

the circle or have him crash into their midst. “What do you think is holding us back? It’s certainly not these!”

Unbuckling the collar from around his neck – denoting his status, even if his status had not been abruptly clear from simply being a predator already – he held the brown, worn leather gingerly between a thumb and a forefinger. Don stared at it as anger coiled in the pit of his stomach and reared its ugly head, a snake’s tongue of fire flickering up to his heart. Bastards! Chaining him! Choking him with a collar! Not a single one of them deserved that treatment. They were better than that. They were *all* better than that!

The wolf snarled and hurled the collar across the dorm, watching it sail away as if from a great distance. It thudded into the wall and dropped lifelessly to the floor, buckle splayed open like a bitch’s legs. He couldn’t remember the last time he’d been around a she-wolf. If he was free, he could have a she-wolf. He could have a family. The wolf rocked his head from shoulder to shoulder, eyes hardening as his muzzle tipped back into a low, eerie howl that echoed around the basement. It was not as if he would be heard. The younger wolf joined in with a broken howl, feeding off his energy, and the others lent their voices to strengthen his.

When Don stopped and looked about him, the faces and muzzles he loved so dearly, his only friends, could have been strangers with that strange gleam in their eyes. Leo the inappropriately named leopard licked his chops as if faced with a sumptuous meal. The wolf growled, fighting paw clenching into a tight fist. Had he always had this side of himself deep within? This side that could rile up a pack to take on their oppressors? It was unlike him, yet so inherently *right* in itself too. Yet in the back of his mind a wicked little voice whispered that he was only acting the part. They could never do it. He was not strong enough. They’d beat him again. They’d hurt his pack.

His pack.

Don hissed through clenched teeth and pressed his fingers to his temples, stifling a whimper. It didn’t feel like he was in control of his own life anymore – though perhaps he was merely taking back what was rightfully his. It was not his fault that he was not used to it.

Rafa’s eyes latched on to the collar and his paw inadvertently rose to his own, muzzle wrinkling. Don’s group of companions looked between one another, ears flicking as their eyes fell down, paws shifting constantly.

“We can be predators again! We don’t have to be servants forever – don’t you see?” He barked, leaping up on to the end of one rickety bed. “What’s stopping us? Our minds? We are stronger than them! They are more than us but they’ll never see us coming! We are made for this! We are made to hunt down what we need while they are made to cower, to hide and flee from danger. We are the ones that embrace it – just for living!”

He paused, eyes as hard as steel.

“We are made to survive.”

“Oh, get off it.” Rafa rolled his eyes and looked to the grey wolf and leopard on either side of him, both younger and more susceptible to persuasion. “What do you think you can do, Don,

bark and chase your tail? We've all been doing what they want since we were born. That's not going to change now."

The wolf snarled and punched his fist into his opposite palm, ears dangerously flat to his skull. His muzzle contorted viciously and Rafa yelped, tail tucked down between his legs, the urge to submit and show that he was not threat greater than the element of free will and knowing.

"Of course it's not going to change if you stand there and say it won't!" The wolf shook his head, trembling as he strove to get the words out where they belonged. "We don't think! We need to start thinking – that's what they don't want us to do and do you ever wonder why that is! Why they chain us? I'll tell you why."

He spread his hind paws further apart on the bed as the mattress creaked, his first smile in months tugging at the corner of his lips. Oh, they had thought they'd hidden the secret years ago, yet they had dug it up from the grave and brushed off moist soil to reveal the truth. The predators knew.

"They are afraid of us."

The predators murmured, bobbing their heads in agreement; it was hardly a strange notion to consider when they were so often chained and muzzled for fear of their teeth and claws. Once, their little pack had even seen a lupine forced to walk on all fours like his feral ancestors. It was dehumanising. And all intentional, all very much intentional.

Rafa sighed and rolled his shoulders, eyes wistful as he looked at a point over Don's shoulder.

"What do you think we should do?" He asked, the first of them to voice the question that was going around all of their heads.

Don didn't know how he had come to be their accidental leader in striking back, standing tall on the bed with their trusting eyes looking up to him. The wolf set his shoulders back, hackles bristling. It was now or never if he wanted them with him. For there was one thing he knew with stinging certainty and that was that he could not do what he needed to alone. He would need every single member of his pack at his back.

"We will take back what's ours," he said, lifting a clenched paw above his head as if in premature victory. "First, this household will be ours. We will have all the food and comfort we have ever dreamed off. Beyond that, our right to be who we were born to be. Predators. We are predators and that is who we shall be."

Don hesitated, a little chuckle burbling up unexpectedly from his throat – it even surprised him. Surely this was no time for mirth? The wolf curled and uncurled his raised paw, spreading his fingers wide. The fur was scored through with burns from years of stoking fireplaces and grabbing scorching baking trays from the kitchen, laden with delicacies to make the mouth water in haste. Modern prey did so like their comforts.

Yet it was not his place to provide them.

“Apart from that... Be whoever we want to be and do whatever we want to do. There’ll be nothing stopping us. Do what you want to do. It’s more than we’ve had so far and no one will be there to stop you.”

He spread his paws imploringly, eyes widening a fraction.

“Don’t you want that too?”

Leo scuffed a hind paw across the floor.

“I do.”

The younger wolf growled, tail lifting as he looked up to Don, eyes fixed on his leader.

“I want it too.”

“Me too.”

One by one, each predator added their voice, growls and yowls rising into a cacophony of rebellious sound – all for the greater good.

“How do we do it?”

Rafa asked the question that Don had half been dreading. How would they do it? What could they do? Was it really as simple as he proclaimed? The wolf stumbled down from the bed, faltering into their midst, and he half expected his pack to turn from him and see him for the faux leader he was. How could he be a pack leader when the prey was his true master still? To his surprise, however, they lifted their paws to him, steadying him, and set him back on his paws as he trembled under the weight of his proposal, what he was asking of them.

The absence of the collar around his neck gave him strength and Don imagined life without prey. It wasn’t such a bad thought, fuelling his desire to free his friends with his cause. Equals. Was that so bad? Not for them, by any means. The prey on the other hand... Well, it would matter less what they wanted at the end of the day. He growled. They’d had their turn and more than their fair share of the years.

But there was only one answer to Rafa’s question and it stirred both terror and excitement into the pit of the wolf’s stomach. He flexed his toes, sinking into a half-crouch as he bared his teeth, weight shifting as if to spring at an imaginary foe, given the slightest provocation. The felines hissed and gave him space, tails lashing, and even Rafa dipped his muzzle in submission. No one wanted to be on the receiving end of Don’s temper – not again. Once had been bad enough for all of them when the wolf had last been pushed beyond his limit. Fur had flown, scars left, and the wolf had received a terrific punishment for his misdemeanour. The funny thing was that Rafa thought that the wolf had deemed it worth it, which scared him all the more. They all knew what the wolf was capable of. If anyone could save them, it would be him and him alone.

Don threw his paws up in the air and spun in a circle, a predator frustrated by the confines of his cage. He wanted to *roam*, to experience – to play! To live and to love. Prey got to love

other prey. Why not him too? He wanted a she-wolf to love, to hold and protect. Him too. He wanted it to be *him too*.

“We *fight*,” he growled, words ripping from his throat. “I don’t know how yet, but I will soon. We’ll come up with something, it doesn’t have to be complicated. Maybe the uncomplicated is the better approach... I’ll have to think. But we will fight. We will use what our ancestors gave us, our wits and our instinct, to take back what was ours. What was unjustly ripped away.”

The wolf swallowed hard, tears that he would not admit to stinging in the corners of his eyes.

“And then...”

He rubbed the back of his paw across his muzzle, ears slanting back halfway towards his skull as Rafa placed a comforting paw on his shoulder, squeezing lightly. *I’m here*.

Don turned his muzzle to the ceiling as his comrades crowded around, sharing the warmth of their bodies, his pack nuzzling in close in support. In his mind’s eye, he saw the starry heavens, stretching into infinity, as his pack hunted in the light of the moon. His imaginary muzzle tilted back to the galaxy above to let loose a howl that spoke of eons locked away. It had been too long since he had seen the outside world without a pane of glass in his way.

He wiped tears from his muzzle, leaning into Rafa with a light wag to his tail.

“And then... And then we shall be free.”

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The predators grew restless about their daily chores as servants of the household. Tasks that had once been commonplace became quickly tedious and Rafa could not keep the scowl from his muzzle as he cleaned dishes in the kitchen, his back to the paid prey animal chef serving up a side of vegetarian maki rolls. Once upon a time, just like in a fairy tale, he knew that predators had had the luxury of enjoying *real* sushi with fish. It was not as if it had even affected prey to have fish products on the menu. Now, even though fish had not ascended to two-legged beings – only land mammals – prey banned all fish and meat products, citing them as barbaric.

What would it be like to *eat*? The wild dog wondered as he swept the kitchen, wiping drool from his muzzle as the unknowing zebra sliced up one long roll of nori and rice into several smaller, bitesize pieces. Rafa could have fitted far more than those little morsels in his jaws but they were not for him but rather for the primped up Persephone and her party of friends. His forehead furrowed and he paused in his sweeping, brush stilling. The gazelle always had a gaggle of friends about her. Would it be possible to cut through them all? They, of course, would have the advantage but he wanted the pleasure of taking the gazelle out for himself. He’d heard the meat was fine.

“Hey!” The zebra struck him across the back of the head, sending him sprawling across the hard linoleum, ears ringing. “Get back to work! Do you think you’re here to daydream, predator! Get to it!”

Nodding quickly, Rafa sprang back to his paws, ears ringing. He fumbled for the brush and jumped to his task, muzzle twisting into a darker scowl behind the zebra's back. His mouth watered.

Soon.

With the predators slacking off their usual pace and grouping together to talk in hushed tones, it was no wonder that the household was set on edge gradually over the course of a couple of weeks. Their activity did not grow unnoticed by any stretch of the imagination, though not by ones who could have put a clean and easy halt to proceedings after years of experiences dealing with predators. The heads of the household, Persephone's mother and father gazelles, left on Thursday evening for a business trip that involved more spas and fur treatments than business itself. That meant that Persephone was left there all alone to have her parties and do whatever studying she did actually do. Likely more parties than studying until her parents returned.

Don was unsurprised to hear her scream for 'the wolf' within a day of her parents bidding her farewell with a chaste kiss on the cheek. The little grey, Sitka, was never called for, just milling about his work with a less experienced paw. It was Don that was the real jack of all trades and handy wolf about the house.

Putting aside his yellow dusting cloth, he wrinkled his nose as he trotted from the dining room through to the living room where he thought her voice had come from. Don coughed. His paws reeked of polish. The gazelle stood in front of the large window overlooking the garden, fiddling with a pink bracelet on her wrist. Around and around it spun, pink jewels catching the light. The wolf pricked his ears. Perhaps they were diamonds, pink diamonds. Those fetched a high price, right? Predators would need money if they were to succeed on their own.

"That was quick for you," she commented, looking at his chest, on eye level with his fluff covered pectorals.

"I'm not normally slow, ma'am."

She started, surprised that he talked back. Standing tall, Don folded his arms across his chest and her eyes narrowed.

"Down."

Slowly, the wolf folded to his knees, knelling up straight to maintain maximum height, though he would have normally sank down as low as possible. He resisted the urge to smirk, eyes as innocent as he could make them as the gazelle huffed. She couldn't force him to obey. It was all a farce.

"You in here too, dog," she added as Rafa passed the open doorway, a stack of laundry in his arms. "Close the door."

The wild dog swallowed hard and ducked into the room, dropping to all fours and crawling when he was within a few paces of the duo. Kneeling, he glanced at Don and noted his

stance, making himself taller in his kneel so that his head was higher than usual but still lower than Don's steady muzzle. The note of submission made Don warm with pride that Rafa especially had taken so readily to his firmer paw of leadership. There was hope for them yet if he could have them listen and act.

Persephone folded her arms across her small bosom and shook her head slowly, eyes hard and disapproving.

"I have heard talk in this house, predator."

Don looked up at her but did not say a word, paws spread on his thighs with the palms facing upward. He would not grace her with a response. He bit the inside of his cheek, wanting to curl his paw into a fist and show his teeth in a snarl that would make her quail against the wall. He would not give her the satisfaction of muzzling him before he'd done what had to be done.

When she received no response, the gazelle pressed on, tapping a hoof.

"There's talk that you predators are up to no good, wolf," she pressed. "I hear many things that you think I don't so you may as well give it up now and inform me as to what you are planning."

Don swallowed his smirk, blinking as dumbly as a wolf could. That was too vague to be certain. So...Persephone didn't know exactly what they had planned, only that they were restless and talking. Good. That wouldn't cause him any issues. Though she thought she could coerce him into talking? Don steeled his resolve. Regardless of past obedience, that would not happen – he would make sure of it. His tongue would *not* betray him.

"I hear your whispers, huddled together with heads bowed close. Did you think that I would not notice you missing spots when you mopped the floors yesterday evening? Did you, dog, think I would not see the dirty dishes stashed under the sink. Bariki would have a fit if he uncovered them." She paused, scratching her ear as her eyes darted between the wolf and dog. "Or my parents. And me. I'm displeased by your behaviour. I have delivered more punishments in the past two days that my parents have been away than they have in half a year. Do you think to take advantage of me while alone here?"

Rafa glanced sideways at the wolf and, finding the wolf stoic, kept his mouth shut, looking straight ahead. His eyes did not move from their spot in space as the gazelle slapped his muzzle, jerking his head to the side. The pain did not hurt as much as all else he'd endured. Rafa took a deep breath, drawing comfort from Don's warmth at his side. They would survive. Together. For even the wild dog knew one thing that was evident in the gazelle's trembling paw.

She was breaking.

Don shook his head and looked down at his knees when more answers were demanded of him, the gazelle flinging her paws comically up in the air as if she had suddenly morphed into a cartoon character from the television set. He tuned out her words, amusement rising in his chest as she grew increasingly agitated, movements erratic and topped off with a childish

little stomp of her hoof. It was a strange feeling, the bubbles in his belly. When had he last found something funny? His brow furrowed. It had been too long.

The gazelle growled, a pitiful mimicry of the growl the wolf boasted, and lashed out.

“God damn it, dog!” She snapped, kicking out at his hip, missing in her haste, and throwing herself off balance. “Where’s your tongue? You had such a mouth on you before, why no words now? You know what is going on, I can feel it.”

The wolf watched her warily and shook his head. His ears dropped back to his skull. Persephone swore – most unbecoming of a lady – and grabbed his collar, yanking his head up so that his muzzle was just below hers. The wolf scrabbled to his paws in a low crouch, coughing and hacking as his windpipe was cut off, eyes bulging from their sockets.

“You *will* tell me what is going on,” she hissed.

Her paws were balled into shaking fists. They didn’t fool anyone. The gazelle licked her lips and cursed under her breath, fingering each horn in turn as if she needed to check that, yes, both were still there atop her head. They may have taken flight in her flailing, if her frazzled mind was to be believed.

Stunned by her display, Rafa whined and tipped his muzzle towards the wolf, sinking further towards the carpet. Don ached to reach out to him, to comfort, but there was not anything he could do with Persephone looming over the two of them, right there in their way. She was always stopping them one way or another.

“Don...” Rafa started, fingers tapping on his thigh, too anxious to remain still.

“Yes!” Persephone wheeled about, jabbing a finger in his face. “What is it? What are you going to say?”

Don held his breath. He wouldn’t...would he?

“We don’t know anything, ma’am,” Rafa whispered, eyes wide and ears submissively lowered. “I’m sorry, ma’am, but we really don’t. I’m sorry about the dishes, ma’am. Ma’am, I’ll do better.”

The gazelle visibly deflated, sinking her weight back into her hooves and giving a derisive snort. Don wrinkled his muzzle as she blew wet breath into his face and waved them off.

“Leave me,” she said, sitting on the edge of the sofa with one ankle crossed over the other. “If there is anything, I will know. Remember that, wolf. There will be no secrets and wrongdoings in my household.”

They didn’t need to be told twice. The predators scrambled to their paws and streaked for the door in a black and multi-coloured blur respectively. They escaped while they had the chance and Don smiled to himself. He knew exactly what they were going to do. And Persephone had told him, without overtly speaking, that it was the perfect time to act. No parents and she was more vulnerable than a calf stumbling into the world from its mother’s birth canal.

Sitting alone on the sofa, Persephone put her head in her paws, tough nails that had once been hooves digging into the back of her neck to leave raw, red scratches beneath her orange coat. A tear of frustration trickled down her cheek and she wiped it away angrily, blinking to clear her eyes.

“I don’t even *like* punishing you.”

*

Persephone’s friends laughed on the sofa, eyes glued to the television. An antelope reached over to snag a pawful of popcorn out of the communal bowl, hoofed fingertips scraping the glass as he clawed for it. Light from the television flickered across their entranced muzzles as they lost themselves in a cheesy film that would no doubt be forgotten in a week or two, but a distant memory in their busy lives. Not much was remembered any more.

Turning his muzzle at the heavy footsteps beyond the living room, the antelope tilted his horns inquisitively as a horde of predators marched into the room, muzzles lifted high. They lined up in front of the prey on the sofa, shoulder to shoulder, and blocked the television screen from view, eyes darting from fur to fur, ever restless.

The antelope wrinkled his delicate muzzle. How strange! Whatever had gotten into them?

“What are you doing in here?” Persephone’s sort of boyfriend, the tall giraffe, demanded rudely. “Get back to the kitchen or wherever it is you’re supposed to be here. Go *away*. We’re too busy to keep you busy. Find something to do.”

The leopard yawned lazily, showing a flash of startlingly white fangs, gleaming with spittle. Before, he would have been muzzled for such an indiscretion.

“Oh, we know what we’re doing.” His eyes glinted. “We’re doing exactly what we want to do.”

The giraffe balked but it was already too late. The predators tensed, tails lashing. One of the wolves let loose a snarl that sent the prey quivering back into the plush cushions, eyes as wide as fawns seeing the world for the first time. And it was a new world indeed.

“Onwards!” The leopard screamed, a feral yowl ripping itself unbidden from his throat.

With a shriek and a hiss, the predators – less than a dozen – struck with claws and teeth and the tools of their trade that had been locked away for decade upon decade upon decade. The motley pack descended on the screaming prey and the wiser sort bolted, streaking from the room in a broken up blur. Fur tore from skin and one of the canines squealed as they were kicked in the ribs, though such a pitiful blow did nothing to stop the victim in the throes of bloodlust. They were far gone from the sane, thoughtful furs they had been, clawing and tearing at whichever prey animal was closest, the fox in the chicken coop. So many of them! So close! All for the taking. Their taking.

Juan, a tiger, slavered, crouched low to the ground as he stalked one fur that had not had the good sense to at least leap out of the way. And now, her time was up.

Blubbering, the squirrel covered her muzzle with her paws and wailed into them as her life came to an end in a searing streak of crimson, pain fleeing before the darkness. Juan licked his chops, revelling in the metallic taste of blood. The squirrel crumpled to the floor, a broken toy tossed away.

See you in the next one, squirrel-girl.

Rafa yelped, snapping at the tail of the giraffe as he swore like a sailor and barely evaded his teeth. The wild dog's eyes followed his ropey tail as he fled, streaming behind him like a scraggly piece of string with the uncombed tuft on the end. It was a strange thing to notice in the moment but the giraffe running away made his legs tremble, whining with the instinctual desire to *chase*.

With a bloodied maw, the young grey wolf howled, tipping his head back and Rafa joined him, barking and wagging his tail as if thrilled that their first strike had gone so well. In all truth, however, they had only killed two furs and, considering how many predators were gathered, it really was a pitiful number. They were rusty, out of practice, and had not learned how to kill. Yet it delighted them all the same.

The hunt was on.

Only Don was nowhere to be found. It didn't matter – the predators were doing well enough without him. He'd arranged the strike and that was more than good enough for the pack. They could do without him, finding buried instinct flaring to their fingertips. Why, they only had to call upon it and it was there! It had always been there. And it gave them *power*.

The giraffe wheeled around the corner of a long hallway straight into Persephone, who grasped at his arms. He clung to her as if for dear life, holding her so roughly that his hooved fingers tore into her fine clothes, a sari far from suitable attire with a rampage flattening her world.

"Richard!" She gasped, eyes wide. "What on earth is happening? I heard screams! Was that Celeste crying? What's –"

"Just run!" He gasped out, paw on the wall for balance as he swayed on his long legs, desperately scraping air into sore lungs. "Gemini, she's already gone, they got her, she's gone, maybe Leopold too –"

"Gone? What do you mean? What's happening? Tell me what's going on!"

Richard shook his head, ears drooping but breath steadier, if not calm. His heart thudded, the song in his head that of survival and survival alone. That was how it worked, wasn't it? He had to survive. Persephone had to survive. He pressed his cheek to the gazelle's, forcing out the words through dry-mouthed wheezes.

"The predators, they've gone wild, every one of them!" He swallowed hard, her body stiffening in his grasp. "We've got to get out of here, run, escape, flee – anything! Out of here!"

He drew his head back enough to look her levelly in the eye, a paw wrapped around each of her tiny biceps. She would be eaten up in one bite.

“Run, Persephone. *Run.*”

Grabbing her paw, Richard hauled the lithe gazelle after him and, without thinking about it, she burst into a run, legs working hard to keep up with his longer ones. Her head reeled with the thought that the predators – her predators! – were on the loose in the house, rampaging as they had in olden days, destroying everything she held close and dear. Persephone whimpered, tugging on the giraffe’s paw as he skidded around the corner to the hallway, front door within reach.

The wolf moved in a grey blur, launching himself through the air with a feral snarl and wild eyes. Persephone watched him fly over her as if in slow motion, adrenaline tingling through her veins, spittle streaming from his jaws in long ropes as they parted wider and wider and wider. Only to close around her boyfriend’s – or not anymore – throat.

Putting the pressure on below the giraffe’s jaw, the grey wolf bore him to the ground, pouring his prey’s life essence on to the expensive floorboards. His breath came harshly and his long, black tongue lolled from his muzzle as he scrabbled, struggles growing weaker with every passing second. Persephone stared in horror, legs trembling so terribly that her knees nearly clacked together. Looking her in the eye as the light faded from his, Richmond mouthed one word: run.

So run she did. She couldn’t breathe but she ran. And ran. Dodging other predators roaming her home without rhyme or reason, she skirted the centre of chaos and, heart pounding, sought solace in the kitchen. Could she lock herself in the walk in freezer until her parents came home? Would the predators

Richmond’s dead eyes glimmered before hers. She’d left the giraffe lying in a pool of his own...no. No. Something twisted viciously in her chest and the gazelle clapped a paw over her muzzle as her stomach roiled, willing herself to not vomit up her guts. Pain shot through her and she didn’t know if she hurt from fleeing or from something more, something deeper that she should have perhaps acknowledged a little earlier than she had. She forced herself to take one shaky step after the other towards the kitchen door, wavering in her line of sight. Her cheeks grew wet.

Richmond...

Closing her eyes against his image, she stumbled into the kitchen and put her back to the heavy door, only to come upon the most unexpected sight of the evening.

“What... What are you doing?” She stuttered out, one paw on the kitchen counter, though her balance was fine.

The wolf sighed and straightened, stretching out the kinks in his back by raising his arms overheard with a soft growl and crack of bones.

“What does it look like I’m doing? I’m icing a cake.”

The gazelle looked between the wolf and the three tier cake as if he had gone mad. Or perhaps she had lost her mind. Don's lips pressed into a hard line.

"Don't get excited." He rolled his eyes, picking up the tube of pink icing. "It's not for *you*."

"Then *who* in heaven and earth is it for?"

Even with the household in chaos and half her friends dead, the demand spilled from her lips before she could stop it. And, once it was gone, she wished she could snatch it back. Yet she had to know, she had to know why he had caused so much carnage only to bake a cake. Why would he even want to bake a cake? The wolf never had cake anyway. Persephone's head spun and she brought a paw to her forehead, eyes half-closed.

"It's for me," he said. "Is that so hard to believe?"

She balked from the callous, snide undertone to his voice, anger flicking back to life in the cauldron of her stomach. A cake? A *cake*? The gazelle growled and Don started, eyes wide at the sudden sound. The icing tube trembled in his paws but he held firm, stance spread.

"Do you have any *idea* what you've done?" She snarled, flinging her arm wide. "Didn't you see what *your kind* has done?"

Don blinked and tilted his head to the side.

"Doing what they want to do. Isn't that what they are doing?"

Persephone laughed dryly, though there was no scrap of humour in her tone.

"Oh, of course they are, if maiming and killing is what your *friends* like to do."

"Though I shouldn't be surprised," she continued, leaning back against the wall, arms crossed over her skinny chest. "You always did take advantage of me when my parents weren't around. It's not unusual. You think I'm weaker than them."

She was suddenly as small and frail as her young years and Don put the icing tube down on the counter, ears folded back. He fiddled with the white apron, strings tied at his back, but could not bring himself to take it off. It looked silly on him, out of place, but he just couldn't. It was what he wanted.

What the others wanted was not what he wanted. He hadn't considered that. The wolf swallowed hard.

"Blood and guts everywhere," the gazelle continued bitterly, sliding down the wall to sit on the floor, legs bent up close to her chest. "I'm surprised to not see blood staining your fur too, wolf. That's all your kind is good for, with those teeth. You like to rip into flesh, do you not?"

"No..." Don shook his head, a low whine building in his throat. "I don't like it. I don't like it, ma... Persephone."

The gazelle looked up, mascara streaking her muzzle.

“You fool,” she said quietly, paw dropping to the floor. “You absolute and utter fool. We were right in what we did. We were right in keeping you chained if this is how you behave in desiring freedom.”

She laughed without humour and shook her head, dipping her muzzle to her knees and hugging her legs to her chest. Tears streamed down her cheeks, dripping on to her legs, dirtied and bloodied from her trials. It had been a long day. She could rest for a while, just a little while, as war raged on outside the kitchen door. He could see her cry. It didn’t matter anymore. She didn’t have to be strong when he had already proven his weakness in the most absolute way possible.

Don pressed his paws over his eyes, blocking out his immediate world.

“I just wanted to make a cake,” he said in a very small voice. “It’s all I’ve ever wanted to do and you and your family stopped me. I wanted to bake cakes. I wanted to decorate. Master... No, the zebra, Bariki, said that was his job. Not mine.”

“Yeah?” Persephone forced out through her sobs. “That’s your problem, mutt. Now you’ve made it everyone else’s problem too. Fucking deal with it. Your mess.”

Don stood dumbfounded as his paws began to tremble, shaking so badly that he could not for the life of him. Outside the door, a wolf howled, and Don jumped, hackles lifting on the back of his neck. His muzzles wrinkled as he scented blood. Instinct was more powerful than a fur’s simple desire.

And yet he clung on to it with the tenacity of a dying man, hanging off the thread of want and life until the very point at which it snapped.

“I wanted to bake a cake.”

The gazelle snapped, staggering to her feet with fists flying in all directions. Don didn’t even flinch, instead holding her at arm’s length as he settled into himself, resolving hardening. Let the bitch scream. He would bake his cake. He growled, ears pinned flat, as the little gazelle fell limp in his paws, hardly about to support her own weight.

“You fool!” Persephone hissed, head lolling to the side, hooves dangling as he lifted her. “Do you see what trouble you’ve caused? Do you not know what you’ve done?”

The wolf swept his gaze around the kitchen, roaming over powdery flour to a cup tipped sideways next to the sink. The contents had spilled out of the glass and clear liquid – water? – dripped from the cupboards. Slowly, the wolf smiled, his grin growing wider and wider until it stretched from ear to ear. The gazelle’s eyes bulged out of their sockets and she squirmed as he lifted her higher, bringing her muzzle up to the same level as his. Don smirked.

“I see furs doing what they want to do,” he told her.

Simplicity rang through his words and, though Persephone scoffed, she had no retort. Don giggled, a wicked little sound that came unnaturally to his lips, and she screamed in his face, throwing her body from side to side in a futile attempt to free herself. But, as she had locked the wolf in chains, he now had her in his grasp. Power surged through him, tingling down to the tips of his fingers.

“If I want to bake my cake, they can also do what they want.”

He glanced back over his shoulder as something heavy thudded into the opposite side of the kitchen door, handle juddering threateningly. A body? One of many, he supposed. But bodies were not so bad if they were a means to an end. It was the way of life, at least for a predator. Don smiled.

“You asked what I see... Well, I see a revolution. Don’t you?”

Dropping the stunned Persephone on the floor, Don stalked from the kitchen with his head held high and his shoulders set back. Joining his pack, he hurled himself into the fray and drove them onwards to sweet victory.

And so the great predator rebellion began, the sparks set off in one household that would not have made a difference in the grand scheme of things if fate had called a different hand. From the decimation of the prey in Persephone’s household, the seed was planted and others around the known world took back what was theirs, bloodying the soil with tooth and claw. Persephone was kept safe by a strong-armed black wolf with fire in his eyes, fuelled by the roar of rebellion for what he believed was a better world.

Predators could have taken the same path and enslaved every prey animal, if they did not add to the bodies in their wake. The outcome could have been very different to what it was. Predators could have reigned supreme with an iron fist – with due right, for had they not been treated unjustly by their overlords, after all? It was a good thing they had a wolf with a fair on his shoulders as their leader, bringing equality to a world that had forgotten that some furs did not want to suffer or cause suffering.

No. Some just wanted to bake a cake.